

A secret agent's life is tough. The secret assignments, the gadgets, the deals... So I decide to put some jazz into my assignments. Music! That's what I need. An MP3 player is the perfect thing to keep me company as I travel from city to city and shop to shop to hunt for the best deals available.

I ask my colleague, Agent Audio, from the Digit Test Centre for help. He brings along special headphones (reference headphones that he uses for various audio experiments) and his audio test CD with some ear-shattering MP3s.

Lamington road, Mumbai, is our first stop. But none of the shops have portable MP3 players, although most of them have a desktop version of a VCD player—a small device, about the size of an ordinary VCP, that can play VCDs, MP3s and audio CDs. It costs less than Rs 3,000, but the build quality is suspicious and the brand names look like rip-offs of well-known companies. The vendor isn't certain whether it'll play CD-RWs. Yet these players deliver. They play MP3s, support variable bit rate (VBR) and have a spectrum analyser (dot matrix) to boot. Not bad, considering the dealer is willing to give a three-month standing replacement warranty. It's too bulky to carry along, but I could convert it and give my old Hi-Fi system a new lease of life. But that's not for now. I'll move on to another location. I am told that I'll find MP3 players only in Customs-notified shops.

Heera Panna, Mumbai, looks like a

MP3

SECRET NOTES

players

good place to get imported goods. Agent Audio and I enter a shop. The shopkeeper shows us an unbranded CompactFlash memory-based 32 MB MP3 player, which costs Rs 7,500. Agent

Audio asks for a demo. He fiddles with the

equaliser settings and finds that the player has less than optimal output. With only 32 MB storage space, it

allows for only six songs of five minutes each.

Another dealer shows us the impressive Creative

Nomad Jukebox pegged at Rs 23,500. It has 6 GB of hard drive space (which can store around 150 music albums or 1,500 songs), EAX surround sound output, a nice

playlist manager and a cool display. But the price.... Maybe we can get the Big Boss to buy this as standard equipment for undercover assignments. If only wishes were horses.

He then shows us the Philips Expanium, which costs Rs 9,000. Agent Audio's eyes shine with pleasure when he sees this beauty—a good build quality and almost zero problems when it came to skipping.

We ask for cheaper alternatives. We are shown MP3 players priced between Rs 6,500 and Rs 10,000. One brand, Kingwood, looks interesting, but Agent Audio shakes his head. Though it's portable and plays VCDs, MP3s and audio CDs and it costs just Rs 6,500, it has no buffer to protect against skipping—it skips and then takes a long time to play again if jostled even slightly.

The dealer also tells us about unbranded 'Chinese' MP3 CD players, but says: "Most of them don't come with any warranty or skip protection buffer. Several users have complained of irregular playback and random skipping in tracks."

We move to Vile Parle, Mumbai, where a vendor shows us an MP3 player. It's a small (and cute) solid-state MP3 player with 32 MB of memory from D-Link. He adds that the demand for these players is low, even though they have a wealth of features. "It is 100 per cent skip free and costs only Rs 9,500." Agent Audio nods in agreement.



■ To test audio quality of the MP3 player, carry along an MP3 test CD with your favourite tracks and a set of audio CDs to the shop.

■ Prefer models with at least a 64 MB memory device to store and play more songs. Check if there is a possibility of adding extra flash memory modules.

■ Look for the ability to play VBR (Variable Bit Rate) MP3 files, files with a bitrate 128-320 Kbps.

■ Look for support for additional formats such as WMA, Liquid Audio or Windows Media 8. WMA files are smaller, enabling you to store more content on the player.

■ CompactFlash-based MP3 players are better as they have the ability to upgrade their firmware.



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

RAM chips

Want to upgrade? Now's the right time to go in for SDRAM. Over November and December, RAM prices fluctuated from a record low of Rs 1,100 for 256 MB SDRAM to Rs 2,350 per stick. You now pay Rs 1,650 for a single stick of PC 133 256 MB SDRAM. So go ahead, upgrade.



The mission's come to an end. Now I must select from among the variety of choices available. On the one hand are the foreign brands—great beauties—and on the other are the cheaper but less feature-rich models. But then Customs-notified shops generally do not give you any kind of warranty or support. The only MP3 CD player that is available through the official channel with warranty and support is the Philips series of MP3 CD players. Ah, well, what's life without a little risk?